

Loving-Kindness

Mettasutta (Iti 22)

Vuttañhetam bhagavatā vuttamarahatāti me sutam:

This was said by the Blessed One, said by the Arahant, as I have heard:

“Mā, bhikkhave, puññānam bhāyittha. Sukhassetam, bhikkhave, adhivacanam
ittassa kantassa piyassa manāpassa yadidaṃ puññāni. Abhijānāmi kho panāham,
bhikkhave, dīgharattam katānam puññānam ittham kantaṃ piyaṃ manāpaṃ
vipākaṃ paccaṇubhūtam. Satta vassāni mettacittam bhāvetvā satta
saṃvaṭṭavivaṭṭakappe nayimaṃ lokaṃ punarāgamāsiṃ. Saṃvaṭṭamāne sudam,
bhikkhave, kappe ābhassarūpago homi; vivaṭṭamāne kappe suññaṃ
brahmavimānaṃ upapajjāmi.

"Monks, do not fear meritorious deeds. For 'meritorious deeds' is another name for happiness, for what is pleasing, desirable, and agreeable. I recall experiencing for a long time the pleasing, desirable, and agreeable results of meritorious deeds performed over a long time. Having cultivated a mind of loving-kindness for seven years, for seven eons of cosmic contraction and expansion I did not return to this world again. As the eon contracted, I went to the realm of Streaming Radiance. As it expanded, I was reborn in an empty Brahma-palace.

Tatra sudam, bhikkhave, brahmā homi mahābrahmā abhibhū anabhibhūto
aññadattitudaso vasavattī. Chattimsakkhattum kho panāham, bhikkhave, sakko
ahosiṃ devānamindo; anekasatakkhattum rājā ahosiṃ cakkavattī dhammiko
dhammarājā cāturato vijitāvī janapadatthāvariyaṃ appatto sattaratanasamannāgato.
Ko pana vādo padesarajjassa.

There, monks, I was Brahma, the Great Brahma, the conqueror, the unconquered, the all-seeing, the wielder of power. Thirty-six times I was Sakka, ruler of the gods. Many hundreds of times I was a wheel-turning monarch, a righteous king of Dhamma, conqueror of the four quarters, who established the security of his realm and was possessed of the seven treasures. Not to mention regional kingship!

Tassa mayham, bhikkhave, etadahosi: ‘kissa nu kho me idaṃ kammassa phalaṃ,
kissa kammassa vipāko, yenāham etarahi evaṃmahiddhiko evaṃmahānubhāvo’ti?
Tassa mayham, bhikkhave, etadahosi: ‘tiṇṇam kho me idaṃ kammānam phalaṃ,
tiṇṇam kammānam vipāko, yenāham etarahi evaṃmahiddhiko
evaṃmahānubhāvoti, seyyathidaṃ— dānassa, damassa, saññamassā’ti.

Then, monks, this thought occurred to me: 'Of what action of mine is this the fruit? Of what action is it the result, that I am now of such great power and majesty?' Then this thought occurred to me: 'It is the fruit of three actions of mine, the result of three actions, that I am now of such great power and majesty, namely: giving, self-control, and restraint.'

Etamatthaṃ bhagavā avoca. Tatthetaṃ iti vuccati:

The Blessed One said this. In this connection, this was said:

“Puññameva so sikkheyya, āyataggaṃ sukhudrayaṃ; Dānañca samacariyañca, mettacittañca bhāvaye.

"One should train only in meritorious deeds, whose happy outcome stretches far; develop generosity, peaceful conduct, and a mind of loving-kindness.

Ete dhamme bhāvayitvā, tayo sukhasamuddaye; Abyāpajjaṃ sukhaṃ lokaṃ, paṇḍito upapajjati”ti.

Having developed these three things that bring about happiness, the wise one is reborn in a happy world, free from suffering."

Ayampi attho vutto bhagavatā, iti me sutanti.

Dutiyam.

This matter too was spoken by the Blessed One, as I have heard.

(Second)

Glossary

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
puñña	puñña	merit; meritorious deeds	Loving-Kindness	Wholesome actions of body, speech, and mind that purify the mind and bring happiness

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
				and favorable rebirths.
metta	metta	loving-kindness; goodwill	Loving-Kindness	The active cultivation of selfless love and goodwill toward all beings, free from attachment or expectation.
dāna	dāna	generosity; giving	Loving-Kindness	The practice of giving or charity, which helps eradicate greed and attachment, acting as a foundation for mental purification.
dama	dama	self-control; self-mastery	Loving-Kindness	The training and mastery of the mind and senses, helping to prevent reactions to physical sensations.
sañyama	sañyama	restraint	Loving-Kindness	The restraint of physical and vocal actions, keeping one established in morality (<i>sīla</i>).
sakka	sakka	Sakka	Loving-Kindness	The ruler of the Tāvātimsa heaven,

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
				representing a virtuous celestial being devoted to the Dhamma.
cakkavattī	cakkavattī	wheel-turning monarch	Loving-Kindness	A righteous ruler who governs according to the Dhamma, bringing peace and stability to the entire realm.

Translator Notes

1. **Fear of Merit (*Puñña*):** The Buddha addresses a common misunderstanding that spiritual seekers might have—that performing worldly meritorious deeds (like giving or building good karma) might bind one to the cycle of rebirth and should be feared or avoided. The Buddha clarifies that merit is synonymous with happiness and is an essential foundation for the path.
2. **Cultivating Loving-Kindness (*Mettā*):** The sutta highlights loving-kindness (*mettā*) as a primary form of merit. Cultivating a mind of goodwill for seven years led to aeons of blissful rebirths in the Brahma realms, illustrating the immense power of mental purification.
3. **The Three Foundations:** The Buddha attributes his past achievements to three actions: generosity (*dāna*), self-control/self-mastery (*dama*), and restraint (*sañyama*). These correspond to the fundamental training of morality (*sīla*) and mental development in the Vipassana tradition.